River's Fable

catslovefish.eth with SeaPunk



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THE VOLES AND THE LAST FURROW

The Voles had farmed the bend for as long as there were Voles, and every spring the River took the outermost furrow. One furrow, no more; you could hardly call it taking.



"It will last my time," said the grandfather, and it did.



"It will last my time," said the father, and it did.



"It will last my time," said the son, and it did, nearly; he died the year before the plough went in the water.



Spring. One furrow gone.



Summer. One furrow gone.



Autumn. One furrow gone.



Winter. One furrow gone.



The son died the year before the plough went in the water.



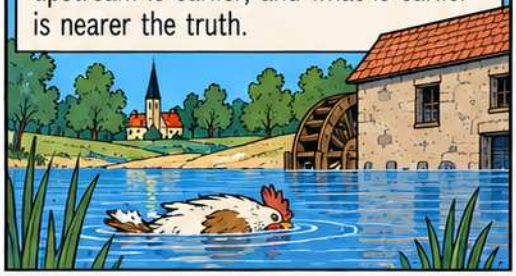
His daughter stood on the last furrow and looked at the River, which looked, as it always had, as if it were in no hurry at all.



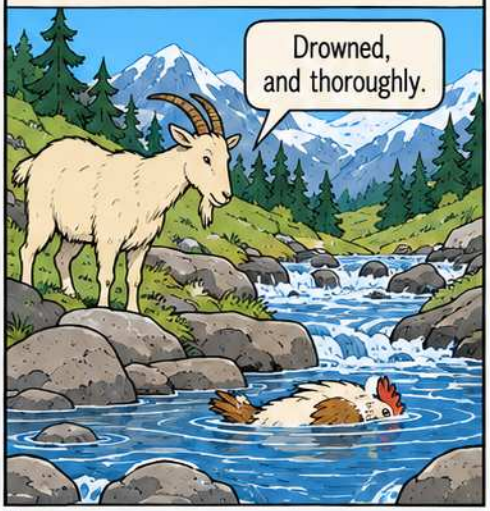
A furrow a year is nothing to anyone but the last.

THE TRIAL OF THE DROWNED HEN

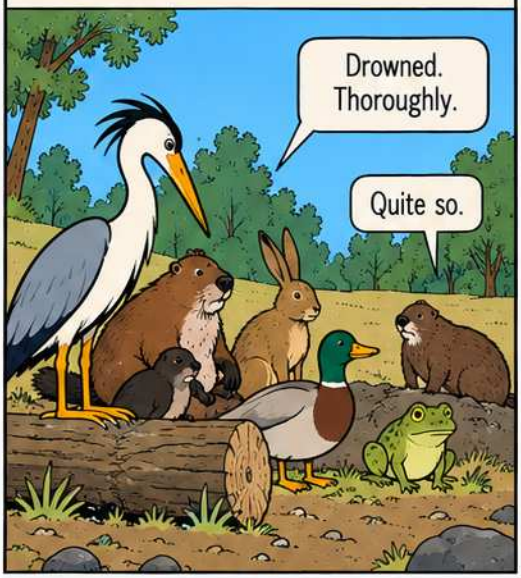
A Hen was found drowned below the mill, and the court of the bend sat to hear it. By the law of the River, witnesses speak in order of their distance from the source, for what is upstream is earlier, and what is earlier is nearer the truth.



First the Goat, from the headwaters, who had seen the Hen float past his hooves at dawn.



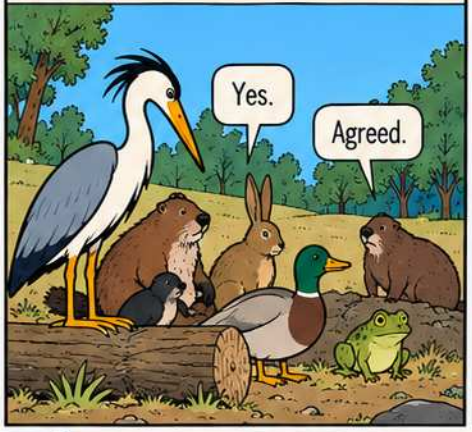
The court nodded.



Then the Heron, from the middle reach, who had seen her float past at noon.



The court nodded.

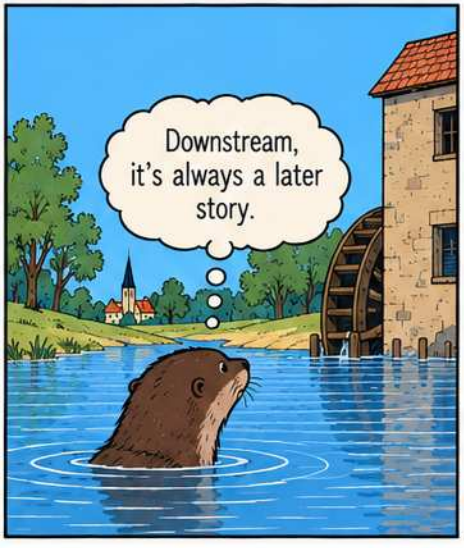


Last the Otter, from the mouth, who had been under the mill and seen the Fox do it.



But the court had risen, for two witnesses agreed and it was late, and the Otter, being downstream, was always going to say something that came after.

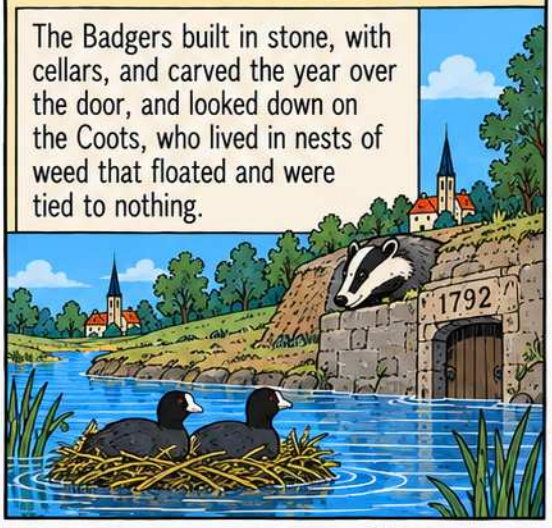




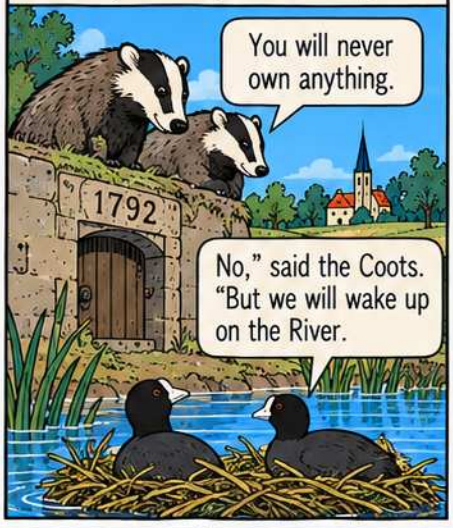
In a river court,
the first to see the body
outranks the one
who saw the crime.

THE BADGERS AND THE COOTS

The Badgers built in stone, with cellars, and carved the year over the door, and looked down on the Coots, who lived in nests of weed that floated and were tied to nothing.



"You will never own anything," the Badgers told them. "You can't even say where you'll wake up."



That winter the River eased itself a field to the north, as it does.



Spring. The Coots woke up on the River.



Summer. The Coots woke up on the River.



Autumn. The Coots woke up on the River.



Winter. The Badgers woke up with a fine stone house, a cellar, a carved date, and a view of mud.







Own what floats where the landlord moves.

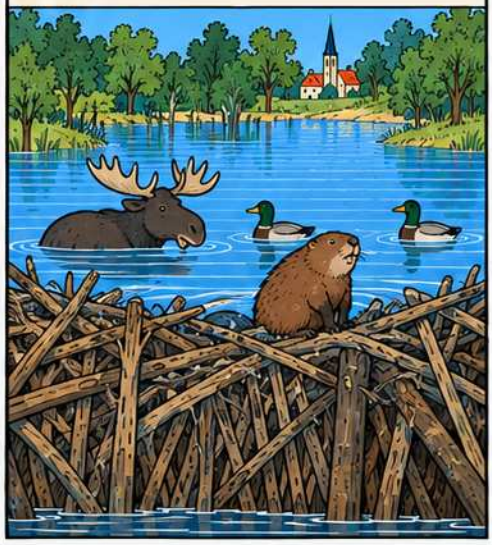


THE BEAVER'S HERESY

On the River there is one virtue, and it is letting go; and one sin, and it is holding. The Beaver preached the sin.

The River wastes itself. Everything it has runs to the sea. Stop it, and keep it.

He felled the alders and stopped it, and the animals above the dam grew wet and fat and called him wise …



… and the animals below grew dry and called him what the dry call the wet.



But a dam that stops the water stops everything the water carries – sand, sticks, the whole heavy patience of upstream …



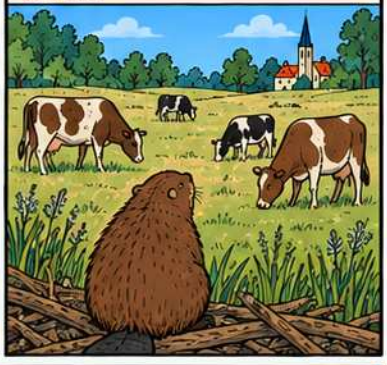
… and the pond that was his church filled with silt …



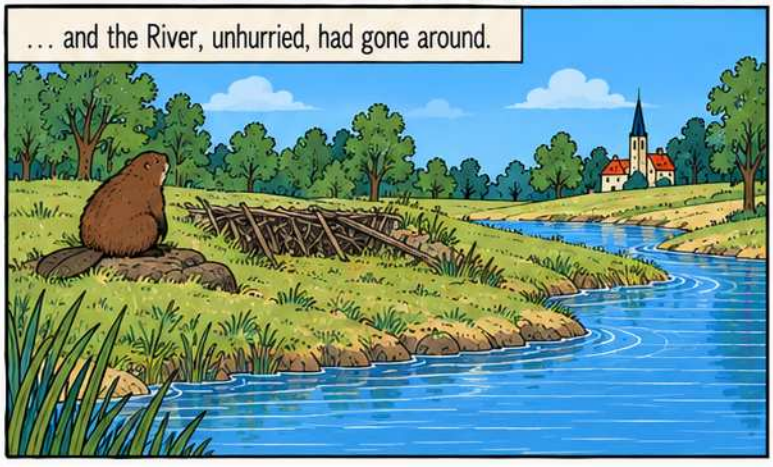
… and then with grass …



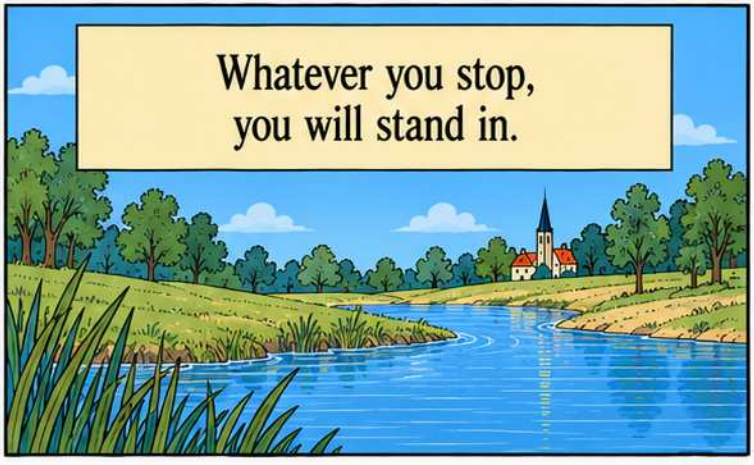
… and one summer the Beaver looked out over his congregation and it was a meadow with cows in it …



… and the River, unhurried, had gone around.



Whatever you stop, you will stand in.



THE VOLE AND THE THREE READERS

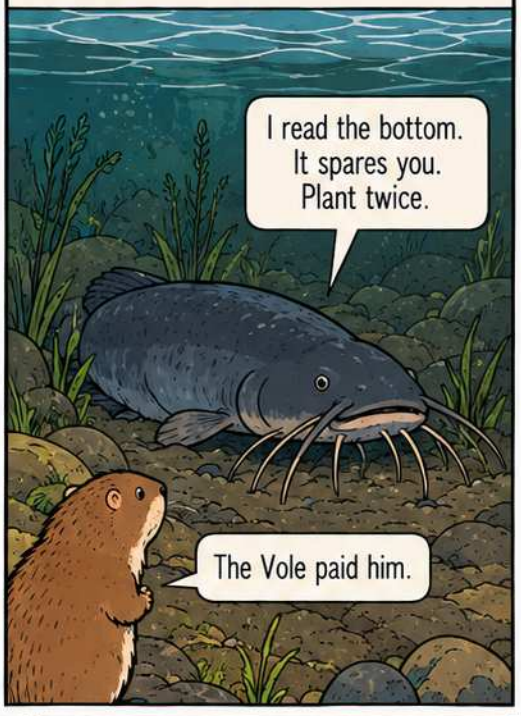
The River says nothing. It never has. So when the Vole wanted to know whether it would take his field this year, he went to those who say they know.



The Stork, on the church roof, sees the whole River at once.



The Catfish, in the mud, feels with his whiskers in the dark.



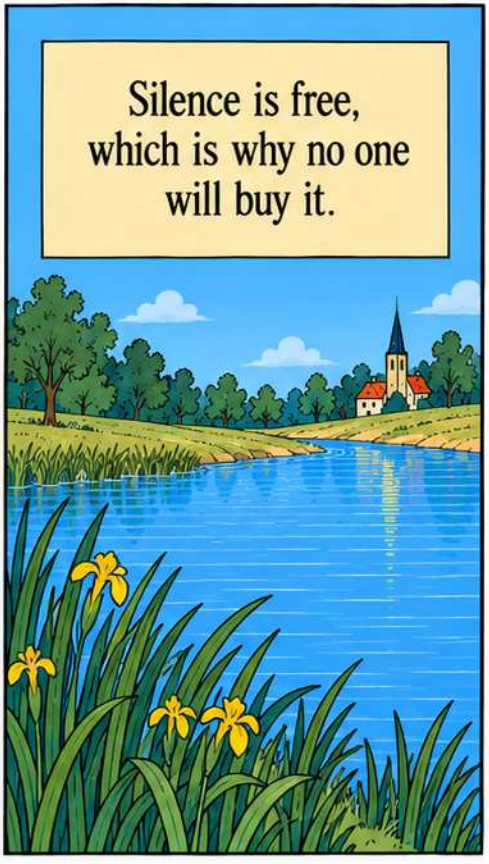
The Dipper, who walks underwater on the stones, had been in it all morning.



And went home with two futures and the truth, which had cost the least and was therefore, he supposed, worth the least.

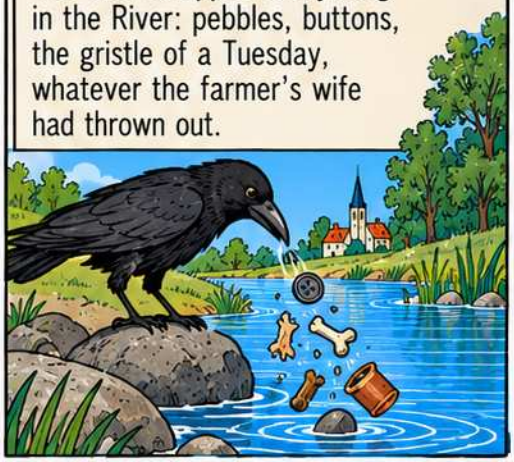


Silence is free, which is why no one will buy it.



THE CROW'S DINNER

The Crow dropped everything in the River: pebbles, buttons, the gristle of a Tuesday, whatever the farmer's wife had thrown out.



It was the custom; the River takes everything and asks nothing, and the Crow found that restful.



Years later, at the Otter's table, she was served a fish, and it tasted of buttons.

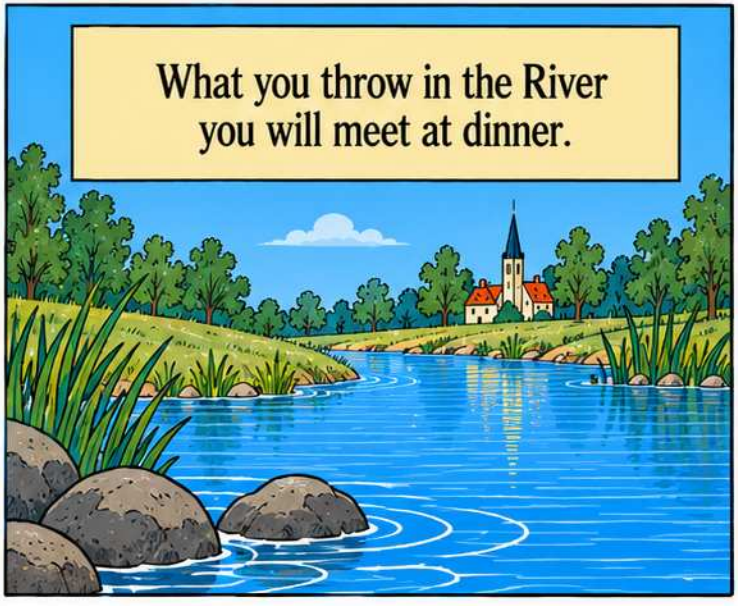












THE EEL'S PILGRIMAGE

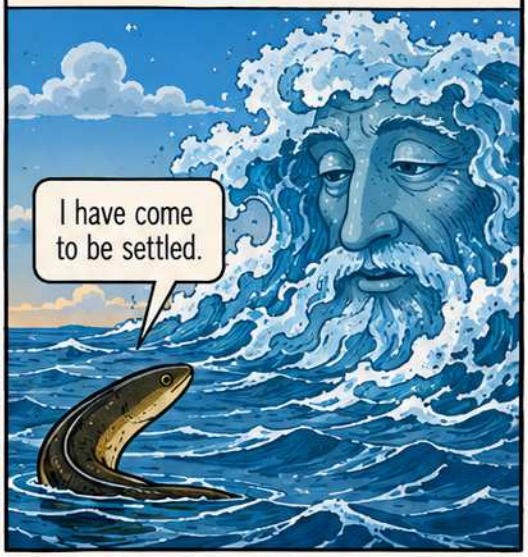
On the River they say that everything is settled at the sea: every grudge, every debt, every unfair thing, made even where the water stops. So the old go down to it.



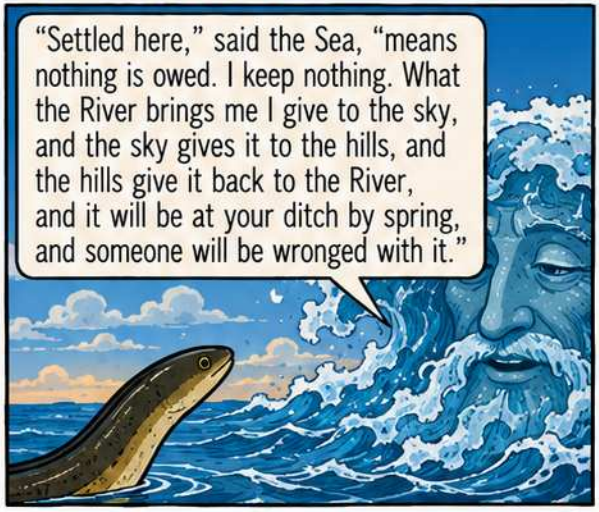
The Eel, having been wronged all her life in small ways, went down: out of her ditch, across the wet meadows by night, down the whole River, past the last buoy.



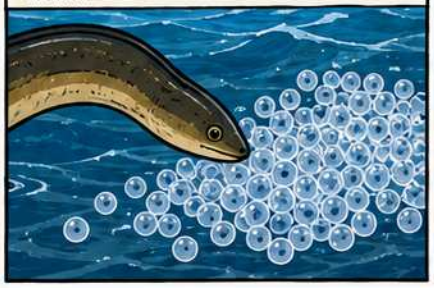
"I have come to be settled."



"Settled here," said the Sea, "means nothing is owed. I keep nothing. What the River brings me I give to the sky, and the sky gives it to the hills, and the hills give it back to the River, and it will be at your ditch by spring, and someone will be wronged with it."



She had no strength to go back. She laid her eggs in the salt, and they went up the River on the flood, glass-clear, and were wronged in small ways all their lives, and went down.







Nothing is settled at the sea;
it is only sent round again.

THE SQUIRREL'S COIN

A Squirrel came down from the hills, where money is gold and sits in a hole, and tried to buy a fish from the Otter with a coin.



The Otter turned it over. "What does it do?"



"It doesn't do anything. That's the good of it. It stays."



"Then it isn't worth anything here," said the Otter, kindly. "Here, worth is what passes. Give me something that's on its way somewhere."

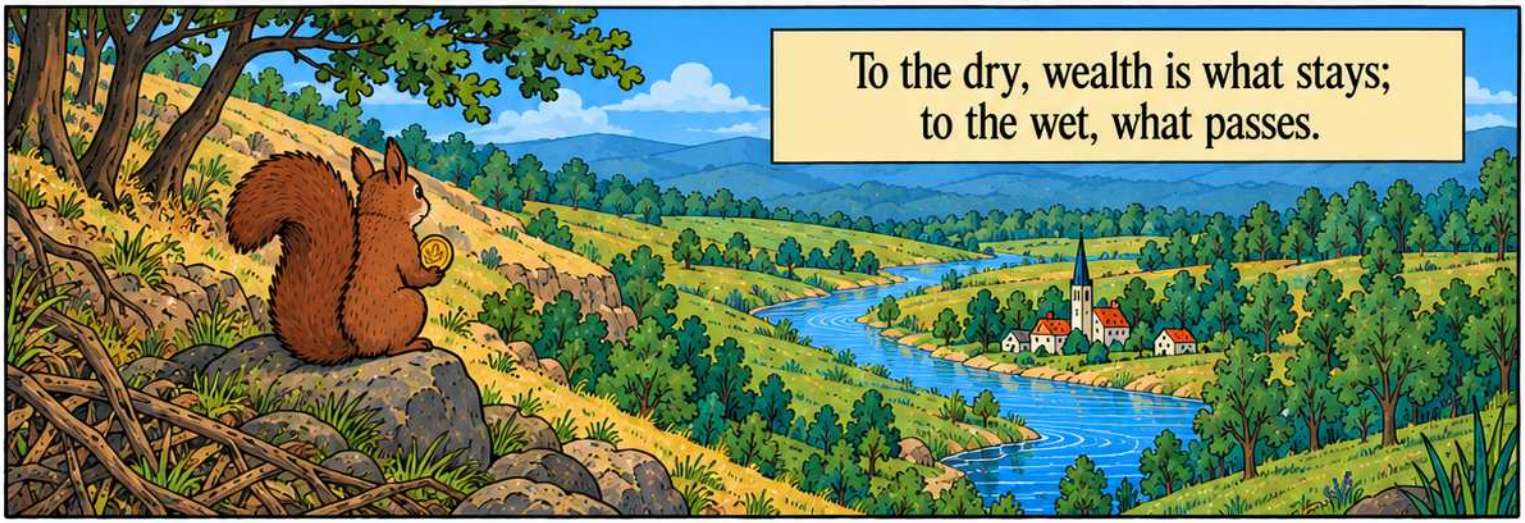


The Squirrel had nothing that was on its way anywhere; that was the whole point of being a Squirrel.



She went back up the hill with her coin and her hunger and told everyone the River people were mad, and they told everyone the same of her, and both were right.



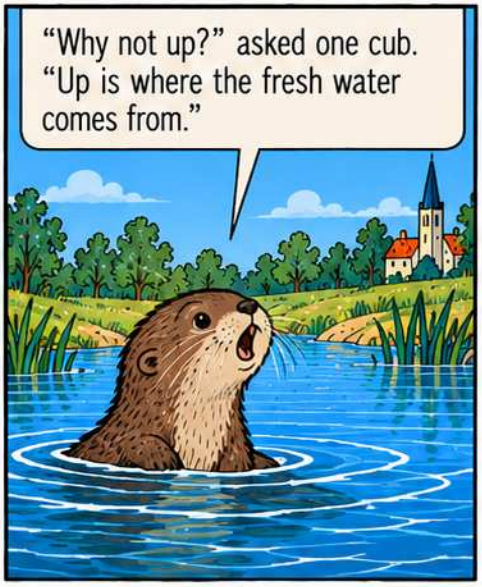


THE OTTER CUB'S FIRST LESSON

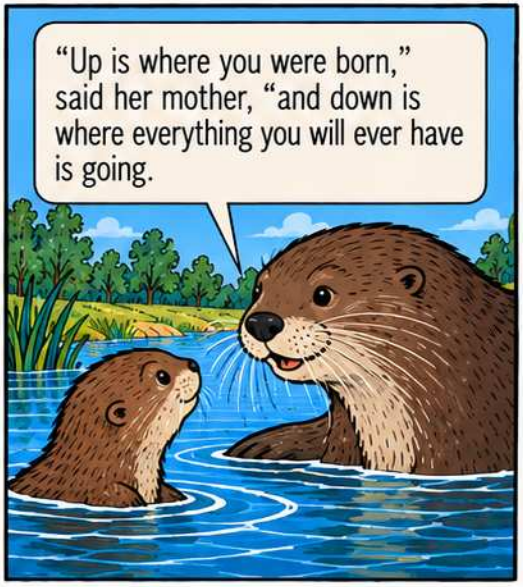
Before an Otter cub learns its name, it learns which way is down.



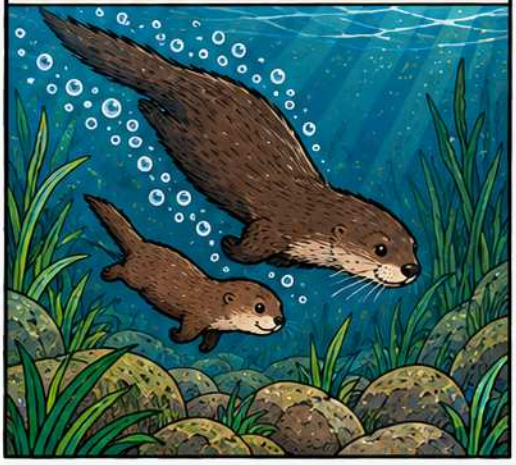
"Why not up?" asked one cub. "Up is where the fresh water comes from."



"Up is where you were born," said her mother, "and down is where everything you will ever have is going.



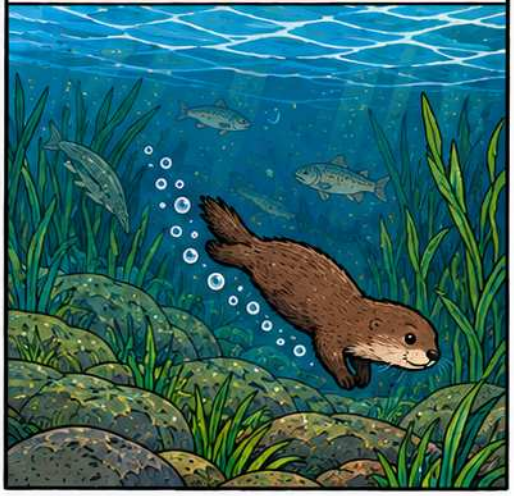
Learn the direction of your inheritance first.



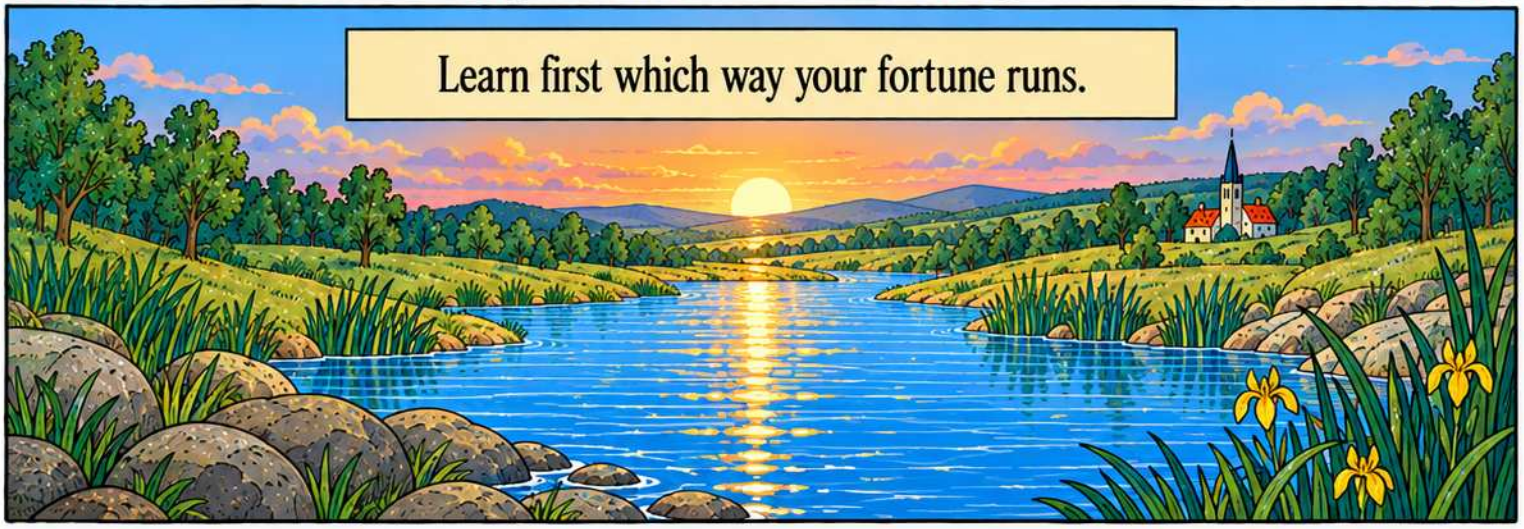
Your name can wait.



The River won't.



Learn first which way your fortune runs.



The Rat and the Toad

The River's bank lent only what the River had gathered: millstones rolled smooth on its bed, oak it had pulled down in floods, seed-wheat it had carried off from farms upstream.

The Rat borrowed two millstones and a sack of seed and built a mill on the bend.

The Toad borrowed oak planks and a coil of rope and built a ferry-landing on the bend below.

Both were to repay in flour and fares at harvest. Then the harvest failed.

The Rat woke to find his wheel grinding air, the bed cracked like old bread, and a new channel glinting a mile off across the fields.

The Toad woke to find the River at his kitchen table, his rope drifting past the stove.

They met on the road to the Heron's counter, each certain he was the wronged one.

It has skipped off in the night like a lodger behind on rent! It has left me two stones and a mouthful of dust!

It has barged in like a bailiff! It has drowned my landing, my rope, and my supper!

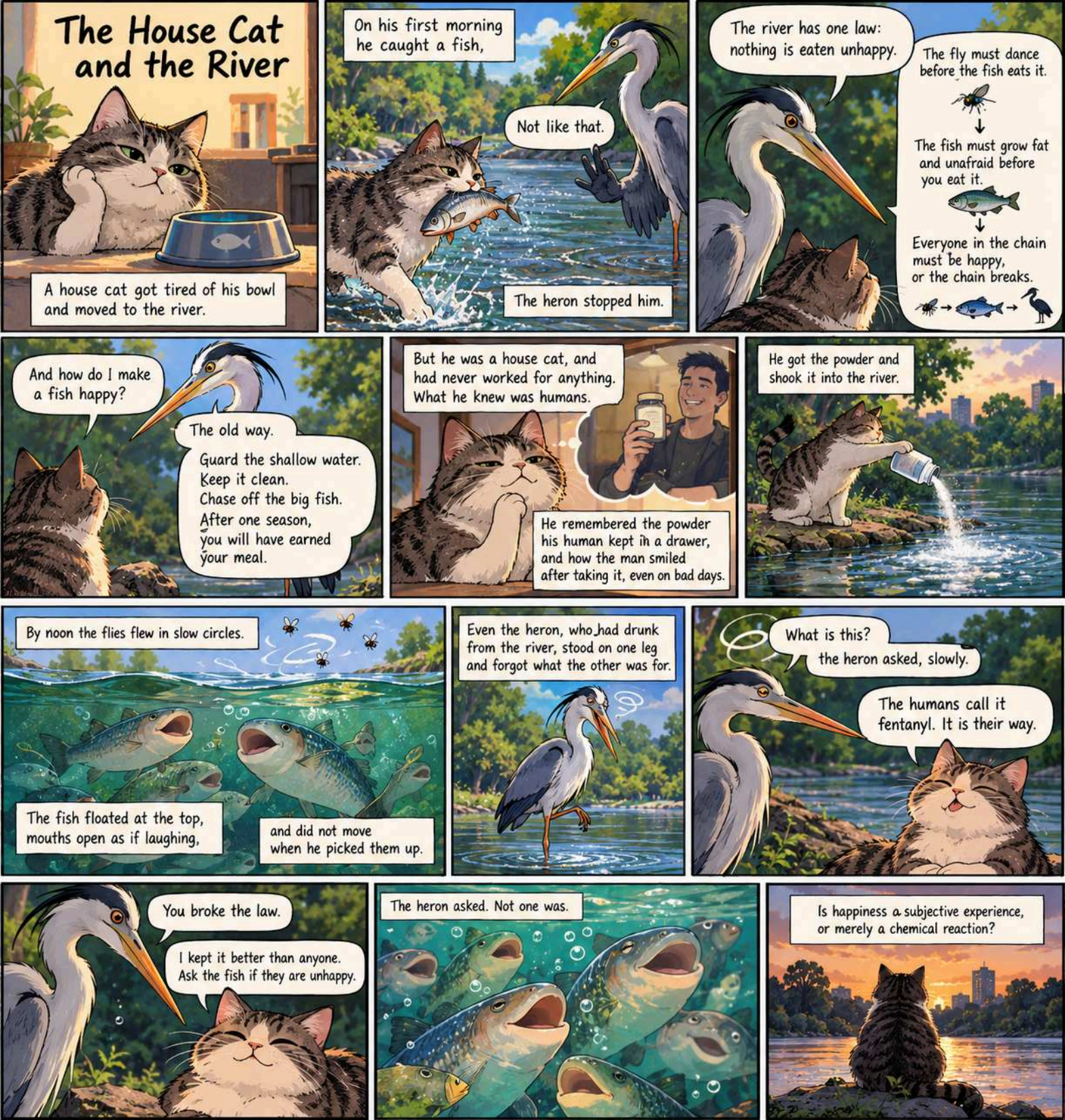
"It has foreclosed on you," said the Heron, and wrote "settled" beside both their names.

But the stones are still in my mill," said the Rat.

And the planks are still under my house," said the Toad.

"Keep them," said the Heron. "The River has no hands. It cannot carry off a millstone or a plank. It can only be somewhere, or not. From you, Rat, it has withdrawn itself, and left you stones that grind nothing. From you, Toad, it has withdrawn the house, and left you planks you must dive for. That is the whole of its reach, and it has never needed more."

A creditor without hands collects by moving, and either direction will do.


The House Cat and the River
A house cat got tired of his bowl and moved to the river.
On his first morning he caught a fish,
Not like that.
The heron stopped him.
The river has one law: nothing is eaten unhappy.
The fly must dance before the fish eats it.
The fish must grow fat and unafraid before you eat it.
Everyone in the chain must be happy, or the chain breaks.
And how do I make a fish happy?
The old way.
Guard the shallow water.
Keep it clean.
Chase off the big fish.
After one season, you will have earned your meal.
But he was a house cat, and had never worked for anything. What he knew was humans.
He remembered the powder his human kept in a drawer, and how the man smiled after taking it, even on bad days.
He got the powder and shook it into the river.
By noon the flies flew in slow circles.
The fish floated at the top, mouths open as if laughing,
and did not move when he picked them up.
Even the heron, who had drunk from the river, stood on one leg and forgot what the other was for.
What is this? the heron asked, slowly.
The humans call it fentanyl. It is their way.
You broke the law.
I kept it better than anyone. Ask the fish if they are unhappy.
The heron asked. Not one was.
Is happiness a subjective experience, or merely a chemical reaction?